From the sprawling urban landscape of Delhi, where corporate ambitions unfold in glass-walled highrises, Ajay Singh embarked on a road less travelled—one that would lead him from corporate professionalism to the earthy wisdom of running a goat farm with 300 goats. The son of a CRPF sub-inspector from Barsana village in Haryana's Charkhi Dadri, Ajay trained as an accountant and worked in banking. The property boom in 2011 led him to switch boats and open a real estate company and purchase 35 acres of farmland near Alwar, Rajasthan. The aim was to sell farm plots. In 2015, the Indian real estate marked nosedived. Ajay, who was living in the village to develop the plots, had invested his savings in land that now had no buyers. "There were times when I had no money to buy eggs and bread for my children," he reminisces.

As Ajay tried his hand at farming, the widespread goat-rearing in the Alwar region caught his attention. It stirred in him memories of village elders referring to goat milk as *niroga*—one that could rid you of all disease. There were those who vouched for its better digestibility over cow milk and being an alternative for lactose-intolerant persons. Ajay also heard of doctors recommending goat milk to dengue, chikungunya and typhoid patients for increased platelet count. He kept a goat for milk, as it was cheap to maintain and, unlike a cow or a buffalo, could be milked any time of the day. The germ of an idea was formed—to supply goat milk to customers in Delhi.

In 2016, Ajay set up Courtyard Farms and through advertisements on Google and Justdial managed to track customers who were interested. He then started to source goat milk from farmers; within a year, he was selling 40 litres a day. In two years, his customer base grew to around 8,000. This pushed Ajay to move his operations from his LIG flat to a 700 square feet unit in Sant Nagar, Delhi, which he then expanded to a 2,000 sq. ft area. In spite of success, by 2018, Ajay had realised that those who sought goat milk did so as a health supplement. Ajay decided to add value by processing it into ghee and curd, which was received well. He was then drawn to the finest expression of goat milk—goat cheese.

Ajay turned to videos on YouTube and also reached out to cheese-makers in India and abroad to get tips. For quality and taste, he asked for feedback for his cheese batches from chefs and food consultants. Within a year, he launched his goat Feta and, soon after, Chevre. Both varieties—deliciously creamy, with a soft consistency—surprised aficionados as they did not use any preservative and earned his products preference over imported, preservative-laden versions. Soon, top restaurants like Indian Accent and Comorin became regular clients.

Yet, Ajay was not content, and his ceaseless experimenting led to more goat milk products. He started keeping his own herd of goats for steady supply of milk. In 2021, he launched his goat Kefir (a drink made from fermented milk), followed by his marinated Feta range. By 2023 end, Ajay's product range included goat milk-based condensed milk, Cajeta spreads and a range of Greek yoghurts. These are now produced in rigorous quality-controlled setups in a 6,000 sq. ft facility in the Okhla Industrial Area. The cream was rising to the top: Courtyard's FY24-25 turnover touched Rs 2.25 crore.

"Imported cheese varities comprise over 70 per cent of the approximately Rs 12 crore market of goat cheese in India," says Ajay. "In three years' time, my aim is to make a big dent in these imports," he adds, as he spreads some Chevre on a roti made on a *chulha*. ■

FACT SHEET

Name of company
Courtyard Farms

What they do
Produce cheese, Greek yoghurt, Kefir, Cajeta spreads from goat milk without any added preservative

Founded in: 2016

Annual turnover
Rs 2.25 crore

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>
> **AJAY SINGH**